

Cheat Sheet: Powerful Prompts for Project Managers

Learning objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Identify key tips for writing effective prompts to achieve desired AI outputs
- Outline the examples of simple and detailed AI prompts
- Discuss prompts for different project phases to facilitate various project management activities

Introduction

Project managers can use Generative AI to generate ideas and reports, collect data, create images, summarize meetings, draft communications, and more. This reading offers an overview of creating powerful prompts to enhance AI results. It includes:

- Effective prompt writing
- Additional prompt writing tips
- Examples of effective, simple prompts
- Detailed prompt examples with context.
- Prompts for different project phases

Effective, prompt writing tips

Effective, prompt writing relies on three key elements: Clarity and specificity, context provision, and output format.

Clarity and specificity: Ensure your prompts are straightforward and convey what you need.

- Avoid ambiguous language. For example, instead of saying, "Tell me about the project," use "Summarize the project's goals, current progress, and next steps."
- Clearly define what you want the AI to do, reducing irrelevant or off-topic responses. For example, instead of "Summarize this," use "Summarize the

key points of this meeting, including action items and deadlines."

- Define the AI's role. Specify if the AI is acting as a seasoned project manager with a specific methodology (e.g., Agile, Waterfall) or as a research assistant familiar with project management concepts.

Context provision: Provide enough context for the AI to understand the task.

- Include necessary background information and relevant details or documents. Clearly state the AI's goal, whether creating a project schedule, conducting a risk assessment, or brainstorming ideas. For example, based on the meeting transcript, extract the key decisions and list the corresponding action items with their owners.
- Set the scene by explaining the situation or the role the AI needs to play. For example, "As a project manager, compose an email to update stakeholders about the project delay and its reasons."
- Give the AI enough background to understand the project, such as briefly describing the project goals, team composition, and relevant constraints.

Output format: Specify the desired format or structure for the output.

- Indicate the output structure you want, such as bullet points, paragraphs, or a numbered list. For example, "List the top 5 project priorities in bullet points."
- Request specific elements or sections in the output. For instance, "Prepare a weekly report that includes sections for completed tasks and a risk assessment."
- Set the tone for the response, whether formal and professional or casual and conversational.

Now that you know the basics, let's explore some additional tips:

Additional prompt writing tips

- Specificity is key: Detailed prompts help the AI understand your needs and generate relevant responses. Request measurable outputs.
- Provide examples: Share a preferred format or style to guide the AI. To include images, use the + sign or image upload button.
- Iterate and improve: Refine your prompts based on the AI's output for better results.

Let us explore a few examples of how to use these tips.

Examples of effective, simple prompts

- Meeting Summary: "Summarize today's meeting notes."
- Email Draft: "Compose an email to the team specifying the project status update."

- Task List: "List the tasks in the Sprint Backlog to complete this week."
- Decision Log: "Summarize the key decisions during the project planning meeting."
- Risk Identification: "Identify potential risks for the upcoming project phase."

Examples of effective detailed prompts with context

- Complex meeting summary: "Based on the meeting transcript, summarize key points, decisions, tasks, deadlines, and follow-up actions: [Insert Transcript]."
- Stakeholder update email: "Compose an email to inform stakeholders about the website project. Mention the completion of the design phase, the start of development, major milestones, issues with solutions, and the next steps. Maintain a professional tone."
- Detailed task list: "Create a task list for the product launch. Include market research, advertising, and sales prep activities. Provide completion times, assign tasks, and note dependencies."
- Project report: "Create a report daily for the mobile app project. Include project overview, completed tasks, upcoming deadlines, budget tracking, risk assessment, and team performance. Use this data: [Insert Data]. Format as a business report."
- Risk management plan: "Develop a strategy for risk management for the ERP project. Identify five risks, assess impact and probability, propose strategies, and assign a Risk Owner. Include a risk matrix and monitoring plan."

Prompts for different project phases

After covering the essential elements of crafting powerful prompts for Generative AI, let us explore how you can leverage them effectively throughout different project phases:

The project lifecycle consists of four key phases.

Phase 1: Project definition and planning

Here are some prompts you can use during this phase:

- Generate SMART goals for the project. Summarize the overall purpose and scope of the project, including its main goals and objectives
- Create a communication management strategy for stakeholders.
- Outline a project schedule with milestones and deadlines in tabular format.
- List the major milestones achieved during the project and the successfully completed objectives.

- Write a summary of the project kick-off meeting held on May 1st, 20XX, highlighting key objectives, assigned responsibilities, and timelines

Phase 2: Project execution

Common prompts utilized in this phase include:

- Identify potential risks, triggers, and response strategies.
- Establish a risk register to track and monitor risks.
- Generate a project status report highlighting progress and roadblocks.
- Draft meeting agendas with discussion points and action items.
- Provide a project update that includes completed tasks, upcoming deadlines, and any issues encountered.

Phase 3: Project monitoring and control

Here are some prompts for project monitoring and control:

- Evaluate project performance metrics and identify areas for improvement.
- Propose corrective measures to get the project back on track.
- Generate reports comparing planned vs. actual progress.
- Develop communication strategies for project delays or scope changes.
- Write a report on the project meeting in the following format: Introduction, Key Points Discussed, Decisions Made, Action Items, and Next Steps
- Describe the significant challenges faced during the project and the strategies used to overcome them.

Phase 4: Project closure

During project closure, use prompts like:

- Create project lessons learned document for future reference.
- Draft a customer satisfaction survey to gather feedback.
- Generate a project handover document for the final deliverables.
- Provide a summary of the final deliverables, including any reports, documentation, or products handed over at the project's conclusion.
- Plan a project wrap-up meeting to celebrate achievements and address concerns.
- Acknowledge team members' contributions, highlighting their roles and the impact of their work on the project's success.
- Summarize the project close-out meeting held on May 20th, 20XX, including an overview, achievements, challenges, lessons learned, final deliverables, team acknowledgments, and next steps.

Summary

Generative AI enhances project management by efficiently generating ideas, reports, and more. Mastering prompt writing involves focusing on clarity, context, and format. As project managers apply the discussed principles and examples, they can expect improvements in the quality and relevance of AI-generated outputs. To boost efficiency, project managers can use pre-defined prompts designed for different project phases.